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Of great value to an African is the bond of friendship formed between two individuals unrelated to one another. This lifelong friend is called *sahwira* in Mashonaland and this friendship is one that can never be broken. The *sahwira* is always available to lend a hand in time of stress or need. The two friends never quarrel and even if rumour has it that one has made some derogatory remark about the other he merely ignores this. Perhaps the best term for such a friendship is a ritual bondship. The relationship is far more than the mere friendship or acquaintanceship which exists in European society and which cannot be relied upon under stress. I do not wish to imply that no true or real friendship exists in European society, but that it is exceptional. The European's best friends are usually members of his immediate family, but the African has, in addition, the *sahwira*. There are times when it is preferable for an individual to confide in someone outside the family circle. Social anthropologists have referred sometimes to such a friendship as a *joking relationship*, thus stressing the fact that the friends can tease or rag one another without either losing his temper. So strong is this bond between the two men that it often extends to their children and after their death good relations remain between the two groups. A more or less prescribed ritual is undergone before this friendship is properly established. A man does not specially look for a *sahwira*, but when two men take a liking to one another after they have met on several different occasions and realize there is a definite affinity between them,  52 one of them sends a token to the other, who, if he wishes to accept the friendship, responds by arranging a beer ceremony for his friend who, in his turn, holds a similar affair. Details of these ceremonies vary greatly from place to place, but after some weeks or months the preliminaries are over and each of the friends has accepted the other for better or worse until the end of his days.

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